

BIHAR ORIGIN

Bihari Mixed Vegetable Curry

Tarkari with Panch Phoron

The Everyday Vegetable Curry of Bihari Kitchens

AUTHENTIC RECIPE · STEP-BY-STEP GUIDE · PRINTABLE DIGITAL COOKBOOK

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ABOUT THIS BOOK

Bihari Mixed Vegetable Curry

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DISCLAIMER

Nutrition values are estimates. Cooking times vary with equipment and ingredients. Readers with allergies or dietary restrictions should check every ingredient label before cooking.

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THE STORY BEHIND THE DISH

Whatever the Season Provides

Known simply as "tarkari" in most Bihari homes — the general Hindi and Bihari term for a vegetable curry — this mixed vegetable dish represents the everyday backbone of the region's home cooking far more than any of its more famous, named specialties. Built around whatever vegetables the season and market provide, tempered with panch phoron (a five-spice blend shared with neighboring Bengal, reflecting Bihar's geographic and culinary ties to the east), it's the dish most Bihari families eat several times a week without much ceremony.

The specific vegetable combination varies constantly by household, season, and even day of the week, which is part of the point — this is resourceful, adaptable cooking rather than a fixed recipe, built to make good use of whatever's fresh and available. Common combinations include potato, eggplant, pumpkin, beans, and cauliflower, though the possibilities are genuinely open-ended.

Because it's so central to daily eating rather than festival or restaurant cooking, this dish rarely gets written down formally in Bihari households — it's passed on by watching and doing, which makes a clear, structured recipe like this one particularly useful for anyone trying to learn Bihari home cooking from outside the tradition.

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THE STORY BEHIND THE DISH

Whatever the Season Provides, continued

CULTURAL NOTES & OCCASIONS

Known generally as "tarkari," representing the everyday backbone of Bihari home cooking rather than a fixed, named specialty dish. Reflects Bihar's shared culinary ties with neighboring Bengal through the use of panch phoron, a five-spice tempering blend. Traditionally adaptable and resourceful, built around whatever vegetables are seasonally available rather than a fixed ingredient list. Rarely formally documented in Bihari households, traditionally passed down through observation rather than written recipes.

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AT A GLANCE

Equipment & preparation

20m	30m	4	Easy
ACTIVE PREP	COOK TIME	SERVINGS	DIFFICULTY

Recommended equipment

- Large, wide kadai or pan
- Wooden spoon

STORAGE & MAKE-AHEAD

This curry keeps refrigerated for up to 4 days and reheats well. It freezes reasonably well for up to 2 months, though softer vegetables like eggplant may lose some texture — still perfectly good for casual meals even if not quite as fresh-tasting as the day it was made.

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WHAT YOU'LL NEED

Ingredients

For the vegetables

INGREDIENT	US	METRIC	INDIAN
Potato, cut into cubes	1 cup	150 g	1 katori
Eggplant, cut into cubes	1 cup	120 g	1 katori
Pumpkin, cut into cubes	1 cup	130 g	1 katori
Green beans, cut into pieces	1 cup	100 g	1 katori
Cauliflower florets	1 cup	100 g	1 katori

For the seasoning

INGREDIENT	US	METRIC	INDIAN
Mustard oil	3 tbsp	45 ml	3 chammach
Panch phoron (Bengali/Bihari five-spice blend)	1 tsp	3 g	1 chammach
Bay leaf	1	1	1
Dried red chili	1	1	1
Ginger paste	1 tbsp	15 g	1 chammach
Turmeric powder	½ tsp	1.5 g	½ chammach
Cumin powder	1 tsp	3 g	1 chammach
Coriander powder	1 tsp	3 g	1 chammach
Red chili powder	½ tsp	1.5 g	½ chammach

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WHAT YOU'LL NEED

Ingredients, continued

For the seasoning (cont.)

INGREDIENT	US	METRIC	INDIAN
Water	1 cup	240 ml	1 katori
Salt	1 tsp	6 g	to taste

SUBSTITUTIONS & SOURCING

This dish is inherently flexible — feel free to substitute or add vegetables based on what's available to you, such as carrots, sweet potato, or bell peppers. Panch phoron is sold pre-mixed at Indian grocers, or can be combined at home from equal parts mustard, fennel, cumin, fenugreek, and nigella seeds. This adaptability makes it one of the most globally practical recipes in the collection, easily built around whatever produce is locally available.

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STEP BY STEP · PART ONE

Preparing the Vegetables

01 CUT TO SIMILAR SIZES

Cut all the vegetables into roughly similar-sized cubes, about ¾ inch / 2 cm, so they cook at a similar pace.

02 SORT BY COOKING TIME

Group the firmer, slower-cooking vegetables (potato, pumpkin, cauliflower) separately from the quicker-cooking ones (eggplant, beans), so you can stagger their addition to the pot.



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STEP BY STEP · PART ONE

Preparing the Vegetables, continued

Chef tip. this staggered approach, common across many Bihari and Bengali mixed vegetable dishes, ensures every vegetable is properly cooked without any turning mushy.

COOKING CHECKPOINT

Having your vegetables pre-sorted by cooking time makes the actual cooking process move smoothly and helps every vegetable finish at the right texture.

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STEP BY STEP · PART TWO

Cooking the Curry

03 TEMPER THE PANCH PHORON

Heat mustard oil in a large kadai and temper the panch phoron, bay leaf, and dried red chili until fragrant, about 30 seconds.

04 ADD GINGER AND THE SLOWER VEGETABLES

Stir in the ginger paste, then add the potato, pumpkin, and cauliflower. Add the turmeric, cumin powder, coriander powder, and chili powder, stirring to coat evenly. Cook covered for 10 minutes, stirring occasionally.



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STEP BY STEP · PART TWO

Cooking the Curry, continued

05 ADD THE REMAINING VEGETABLES

Add the eggplant and beans, along with the water and salt. Cover and cook for another 12–15 minutes, stirring occasionally, until all the vegetables are tender.

Texture indicator. the curry should have a light, thin gravy coating the vegetables, with each piece tender but still holding its shape.

06 ADJUST AND FINISH

Taste and adjust salt and seasoning as needed. Simmer uncovered for a final few minutes if the gravy needs to reduce slightly.

MISTAKE TO AVOID

Adding all the vegetables to the pot at the same time, regardless of their different cooking times, is the most common mistake — it leaves some pieces overcooked while others remain firm. Stagger the additions as described.

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SERVING & PAIRING

How to serve



Traditional Style

- Served hot with steamed rice or roti, a staple everyday meal across Bihari households.
- Often paired with a simple dal for a complete, balanced everyday meal.

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SERVING & PAIRING

How to serve, continued

Family Style

- A large shared pot, practical for feeding the whole family with whatever vegetables were on hand that day.

Modern Pairing

- Works well as a light, flexible vegetable side dish alongside any protein or grain of your choice.

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RESTAURANT-GRADE TRICKS

Chef secrets

Getting the Balance Right

- Staggering when each vegetable joins the pot, based on cooking time, is the real secret to an evenly cooked dish.
- Panch phoron's distinct blend of five whole spices gives this curry a flavor profile genuinely different from a simple cumin-based tempering.

Make-Ahead & Meal Prep

- This curry is genuinely convenient for meal prep, holding up well over several days in the refrigerator.
- Feel free to adjust the vegetable combination based on what needs using up in your kitchen that week.

RESTAURANT TRICK

Some cooks finish the dish with a small amount of ghee stirred in at the end for extra richness, particularly for a special version of this otherwise everyday dish.

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BONUS CONTENT

Nutrition, variations & FAQ

APPROXIMATE NUTRITION, PER SERVING

135 kcal	3 g	19 g	6 g	5 g
CALORIES	PROTEIN	CARBOHYDRATES	FAT	FIBER

Estimates only; actual values vary with oil and portion size.

ALLERGEN GUIDE

Contains, based on the ingredient list: Mustard. Check packaged spices and asafoetida, which may contain wheat, and verify against your own ingredients.

REGIONAL VARIATIONS

Seasonal Tarkari	the flexible, everyday version featured here, built around whatever vegetables are available.
Dry Tarkari	a less saucy version, cooked down further with less water for a drier side dish.
Tarkari with Bari	some households add sun-dried lentil bari to this curry for extra protein and texture.

Can I use different vegetables?

Yes — this dish is inherently flexible, and substituting or adding vegetables based on availability is completely in keeping with its everyday, adaptable tradition.

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BONUS CONTENT

Nutrition, variations & FAQ, continued

Why are my vegetables unevenly cooked?

Likely all the vegetables were added to the pot at once. Stagger additions based on cooking time, as described in the instructions.

Is this dish very spicy?

It's generally mild to moderate, more warmly spiced than fiery — adjust the chili quantity to your preference.

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REFERENCE

Ingredient glossary



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REFERENCE

Ingredient glossary, continued

GLOSSARY

Tarkari	a general Hindi/Bihari term for a vegetable curry.
Panch Phoron	a five-spice blend of mustard, fennel, cumin, fenugreek, and nigella seeds, shared with neighboring Bengal.
Sorson Tel	Hindi for mustard oil, used throughout Bihari cooking for its distinctive flavor.
Bari	sun-dried lentil dumplings, sometimes added to this curry for extra texture.

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PRINTABLE RECIPE CARD

Bihari Mixed Vegetable Curry

20m	30m
ACTIVE PREP	COOK TIME
4	Easy
SERVINGS	DIFFICULTY

VEGETABLES

Potato	150 g
Eggplant	120 g
Pumpkin	130 g
Green beans	100 g
Cauliflower florets	100 g

SEASONING

Mustard oil	45 ml
Panch phoron	3 g
Bay leaf	1
Dried red chili	1
Ginger paste	15 g
Turmeric powder	1.5 g
Cumin powder	3 g
Coriander powder	3 g
Red chili powder	1.5 g
Water	240 ml
Salt	6 g

METHOD

01 **Cut to similar sizes.** Cut all the vegetables into roughly similar-sized cubes, about ¾ inch / 2 cm, so they cook at a similar pace.

02 **Sort by cooking time.** Group the firmer, slower-cooking vegetables (potato, pumpkin, cauliflower) separately from the quicker-cooking ones (eggplant, beans), so you can stagger their addition to the pot.

03 **Temper the panch phoron.** Heat mustard oil in a large kadai and temper the panch phoron, bay leaf, and dried red chili until fragrant, about 30 seconds.

04 **Add ginger and the slower vegetables.** Stir in the ginger paste, then add the potato, pumpkin, and cauliflower.

05 **Add the remaining vegetables.** Add the eggplant and beans, along with the water and salt.

06 **Adjust and finish.** Taste and adjust salt and seasoning as needed.

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BEFORE YOU SHOP

Shopping list

☐ Potato	150 g	☐ Eggplant	120 g
☐ Pumpkin	130 g	☐ Green beans	100 g
☐ Cauliflower florets	100 g	☐ Mustard oil	45 ml
☐ Panch phoron	3 g	☐ Bay leaf	1
☐ Dried red chili	1	☐ Ginger paste	15 g
☐ Turmeric powder	1.5 g	☐ Cumin powder	3 g
☐ Coriander powder	3 g	☐ Red chili powder	1.5 g
☐ Salt	6 g		

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